

Figure 5: The GnuCash window

GnuCash

GnuCash is the flagship accountancy software for small businesses. Although it's only a single-user tool, it can well manage the finances of a small business. GnuCash is a double-entry accounting tool, with features like checking, funds, stocks, possessions, costs, and much more. It offers regular transactions, financial procedures, and importing, among other things.

Features: GnuCash is freely available open source software that can manage complex account operations, along with other required tasks to run a small business. Users can even set up an assortment of account types.

Pros: 1. It is freely available and can run on Windows, Mac and Linux operating systems.

2. It supports various currencies and languages.

Cons: 1. It is not as user-friendly as other such tools are.

2. Also, it can be too convoluted for beginners.

Evolution

Evolution is to open source what Microsoft Outlook is to licensed software. A groupware client with e-mail, calendar, jobs, links, and notes, it will assist in keeping you connected and informed. Evolution is accessible only to Linux users. People have made several attempts to bring it to Windows, but have failed. Windows users can however connect Evolution with Microsoft Exchange, for which there are many tools available.

The future of open source

Companies have discovered the significance of open source and the key role it plays in developing pioneering software. Twitter's messaging app is a first-class example of how open source can be effectively and securely used, and how global companies are driving the adoption of open source software. Because Twitter has open sourced its messaging podium, it gave an assortment of other companies the capability to take advantage of the direct messaging capabilities it developed.

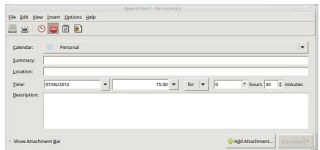


Figure 6: Creating appointments in Evolution

Today, even top financial institutions like Goldman Sachs comprehend the significance of open source.

Profit for users

For developers, profit is not the only motive—though one of the biggest advantages of open source software is that it is all free. The example of Ubuntu Linux mentioned earlier makes it very clear that unlike Windows, you can install or sell as many copies of Ubuntu as you want, without any restrictions. Also, in case, you're setting up a server, you can freely install Linux on it. For instance, if you're setting up virtualised servers, you can effortlessly duplicate a single Ubuntu server. You don't have to be anxious about licensing and about how many instances of Linux you're authorised to run.

An open source program is also more versatile and flexible. For example, after seeing the new interface of Windows 8, many long-term Windows users were disappointed. Since Windows is closed source, no Windows user can take over the Windows 7 interface, alter it, and make it work appropriately on Windows 8.

In the case of a Linux desktop like Ubuntu, for instance, if there is a new desktop interface that many users are not fans of, users have more options. Like when GNOME 3 was released, Linux desktop users were similarly turned off. Some of them took the code to the older version, GNOME 2, and customised it to make it run on the most recent Linux distributions, as in MATE. Folks even took the code to GNOME 3 and altered it to make it function in a way they preferred, as in Cinnamon. There were people who switched to existing optional desktops. If Windows had been open source, Windows 8 users would have had more options.

Open source software even permits developers to stand on the shoulders of giants and make their own software. The Android and Chrome operating systems were built on Linux and some other open source software. The core of Apple's OS X and iOS was made up of open source code, too. 

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